Employee Handbook

Internal draft - approval required before employee use

Effective date: Pending approval

Policy owner: People Operations

1. Welcome and Purpose

Northstar Labs is a remote-first United States technology company. This handbook describes shared employment practices and directs employees to the detailed policies that govern benefits, leave, remote work, expenses, and workplace conduct.

This handbook is a policy-navigation resource. It does not create an employment contract or guarantee employment for a particular duration. Where federal, state, or local law provides a greater right or benefit, Northstar Labs will follow the applicable law. Employees should contact People Operations when an individual situation requires review.

2. Employment Relationship

Employment with Northstar Labs is at will where permitted by law. Either the employee or Northstar Labs may end employment at any time, with or without notice or cause, subject to applicable law. Only the Chief Executive Officer may approve a written agreement that changes the at-will relationship.

Employees are classified as exempt or nonexempt under applicable wage-and-hour rules. A full-time employee is regularly scheduled to work at least 30 hours per week. A part-time employee is regularly scheduled below 30 hours per week. Classification affects benefit eligibility but does not change the obligation to record time accurately when required.

3. Equal Opportunity and Accommodation

Northstar Labs provides equal employment opportunity and prohibits discrimination based on a characteristic protected by applicable law. The company will consider reasonable workplace accommodations for disability, pregnancy-related limitations, and sincerely held religious practices through an interactive process.

Employees may request an accommodation from People Operations. Managers who receive a request must forward it promptly and must not seek medical details beyond what People Operations authorizes.

4. Work Schedule and Availability

Northstar Labs supports flexible schedules while maintaining reliable collaboration. Normal collaboration hours are 10:00 a.m. through 3:00 p.m. Eastern Time, Monday through Friday, excluding company holidays. Employees are expected to be reachable during those hours unless they have approved leave, an agreed schedule, or an emergency.

Managers set role-specific schedules based on team coverage, customer commitments, time zones, and applicable law. Flexibility does not remove attendance, availability, or performance expectations.

4.1 Workweek

The standard payroll workweek begins Monday at 12:00 a.m. and ends Sunday at 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time. Pay schedules and payday dates are communicated through the payroll system.

5. Pay and Timekeeping

Nonexempt employees must record all time worked each day using the designated timekeeping system. Off-the-clock work is prohibited. Employees must report missed punches or corrections to their manager as soon as possible.

Nonexempt employees must obtain manager approval before working overtime. Northstar Labs will pay for all hours the company knew or should have known were worked, even if advance approval was not obtained. Working unapproved overtime may lead to coaching or corrective action, but it will not result in withholding earned pay.

Payroll questions should be reported to People Operations promptly. No employee may alter another employee's time record without documented authorization.

6. Workplace Expectations

Employees must act honestly, protect confidential information, comply with security requirements, use company systems responsibly, and treat colleagues, customers, and business partners with respect. The Code of Conduct and Reporting Policy provides reporting channels and the non-retaliation commitment.

Employees must disclose actual or potential conflicts of interest and must not use their role for improper personal benefit. Company records must be accurate, complete, and retained according to applicable requirements.

7. Remote Work

Remote work is the normal arrangement for eligible Northstar Labs roles. Employees must maintain an approved work location, a safe and professional workspace, reliable connectivity, and the security controls described in the Remote Work and Information Security Policy.

Working from a location outside an employee's approved state can create tax, payroll, insurance, and employment-law obligations. Review the Remote Work and Information Security Policy before changing work location or combining travel with work.

8. Time Away From Work

Northstar Labs provides paid time off, sick leave, paid holidays, parental leave, and other forms of leave. Eligibility, notice, documentation, and approval requirements are defined in the Leave and Time Off Policy. Employees should not assume that notifying a colleague is the same as submitting a leave request.

9. Benefits

Eligible employees may participate in the programs described in the Benefits Guide. The formal plan documents control if this handbook or the guide differs from a plan document. People Operations can help employees identify the controlling document but cannot give personal tax, investment, or legal advice.

10. Policy Administration

People Operations owns this handbook and coordinates periodic review with company leadership and legal counsel. Northstar Labs may interpret, revise, suspend, or replace policies, subject to applicable law and required notice.

Employees are responsible for reading policy updates and asking questions when a requirement is unclear. Managers may not create exceptions to written policy unless the policy names them as an approver or People Operations documents the exception.

11. Questions and Reporting

General policy questions may be sent to People Operations through the internal service channel. Concerns about misconduct may be raised through any reporting channel in the Code of Conduct and Reporting Policy. Northstar Labs prohibits retaliation against a person who raises a good-faith concern or participates in an investigation.